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**HOLDING THE STRINGS** Top, B.S. Yediyurappa and son Vijayendra; Haryana's M.L. Khattar and CM Nayab Saini

meanwhile, does all the organisational work. The 'dual' leadership has added to the confusion of the cadre.

The deeper problem, however, lies in the lack of a formal organisational structure in the mandals and districts. For more than two decades, the party had been dependent on SAD for its rural outreach. Then came the breach, and the residual anger from the farm union protests in 2020-21. The 2022 assembly election (two seats out of 117), and later the Lok Sabha poll (zero seats), were both washouts for the BJP. The next assembly polls are expected in February 2027. The national BJP leadership has to decide soon whether to rebuild the Punjab unit around its long-time organisational hands or rely on a newer crop of leaders who have defected from rival parties.

## CAPITAL CONUNDRUM

In Delhi, the challenge before the BJP is not electoral weakness but internal cohesion. While the party has long dominated parliamentary politics in the capital, it has struggled to convert that advantage into sustained dominance in local politics. That may have changed in February 2025, when the party finally stormed back to power in Delhi after 27 years.

A year has now passed, and the BJP central leadership is looking to consolidate the gains. To do so, it is essential they have a state president capable of unifying the many factions within the Delhi unit. The choice is also whether to have a high-profile MP/ MLA as a president, and even which community to give representation to. Ironically, the BJP's electoral successes in Delhi have added more layers of complexity to the selection process. The party had all seven Lok Sabha seats in 2024 and went on to decisively defeat the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in the 2025 assembly election.

For now, Virendra Sachdeva continues to lead the organisation (he belongs to the Punjabi community which had decisively moved towards AAP in the past). The central leadership is weighing whether to continue with Sachdeva or bring in a more visible political face capable of energising the cadre and sharpening the party's political messaging. The stakes are high because the BJP now runs what its leaders describe as a "triple-engine government" in the capital—in power at the Centre, in the state government as well as in the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD).

**FOR THE DELHI BJP, THE CIVIC POLLS IN 2027 IS CRUCIAL, A FINAL VERDICT ON WHETHER THE RECENT WINS HAVE LED TO DURABLE GRASSROOTS SUPPORT**

A decision on the state president also carries implications beyond the immediate organisational question. The next MCD elections are due in 2027, and the party cannot afford to lose momentum, given that main rival AAP has got a major impetus with the positive court ruling in the Liquorgate case. For the BJP, the civic polls will be an important verdict on whether the wins in the recent past have translated into durable grassroots support. A win under a new command would, for all purposes, send the right signals to the other recalcitrant states as well. ■